

Rialto Bridge

Location Venice, Italy

There are only four bridges over Venice's Grand Canal. The oldest and most celebrated of these is the Rialto. It was completed in 1591, to designs by the aptly named Antonio da Ponte. It was the first stone bridge over the canal, replacing a number of wooden bridges that were prone to collapsing. It represented a significant engineering challenge, not so much because of its 157-ft (48-m) span but because of its substantial 26-ft (8-m) width—the result of the need for two rows of shops on the bridge to generate revenues for its upkeep. At its center is a pedimented triumphal arch flanked on each side by six arches. Elegant balustrades form pedestrian passages on both sides of the bridge.

Bridge of Sighs

Location Venice, Italy

The limestone Bridge of Sighs—a name coined only in the early 19th century, by Lord Byron—links the courtroom of the Doge's Palace to the heavily rusticated New Prison. It was built in 1600 by Antonio Contino. It may be small, spanning only 36 ft (11 m), but it remains among Venice's most instantly recognizable sights. It is supported by a shallow arch, the shape of which is echoed by the pediment that tops the bridge, on which are curving, wavelike volutes. Two square windows with stone grills on each side of the bridge are flanked by diminutive banded pilasters. Eleven slightly menacing carved stone heads line the lower arch.

► THE ARCHED AND ENCLOSED STRUCTURE OF THE BRIDGE OF SIGHS

